Spring 2026 Course Syllabus - Politics of China

Course	PSCI4313.001
Course Title	Politics of China
Instructor	Kelvin Chun-Man Chan
Term	Spring 2026
Meetings	Monday & Wednesday, 1:00pm-2:15pm, GR 3.606

Instructor's Contact Information

Office Location	GR 3.318
Email Address	kelvinchunman.chan@utdallas.edu
Office Hours	Monday & Wednesday, 12:00pm- 1:00pm (by appointment)
Other Information	For all UTD emails, please include "[PSCI4313]" and your full name in the subject line in any email you send to me or to a Teaching Assistant.

General Course Information

Pre-requisites, Co-requisites, & other restrictions	None required. All majors are welcome to take this course and no prior knowledge of course content is required.
Course Description	This course focuses on China's political history, the three political systems of modern China and how it is connected with the world, in particular the United States. Students will study China's political and economic development, its role in the global economy and the potential for a new world order. The course addresses special issues, especially the democratization of Greater China including Taiwan, Hong Kong, and Macao and China's own democratic experiments in local village elections.

Learning Outcomes	Upon successful completion of this course, students will be able to: 1) Develop strong knowledge base of political institutions, actors and important political events in China 2) Build expertise in at least one particular area in China politics, public policy and/or political economy
Required Texts & Materials	Joseph, William ed. 2024. *Politics in China. Fourth edition*. New York: Oxford University Press. Saich, Tony. 2015. *Governance and Politics of China, Fourth Edition*. New York: Palgrave.
Suggested Texts, Readings, & Materials	deLisle, Jacques, and Guobin Yang, eds. 2022. *The Party Leads All: The Evolving Role of the Chinese Communist Party*. Brookings Institution Press. Fewsmith, J. 2013. *The logic and limits of political reform in China*. New York: Cambridge University Press. Kang, D. C. 2007. *China Rising: Peace, Power and Order in East Asia*. New York: Columbia University Press. Lieberthal, K. 2004. *Governing China: from revolution through reform*. 2nd ed. New York: W. W. Norton. Shambaugh, D. 2021. *China's Leaders: From Mao to Now*. John Wiley & Sons Please note that on certain class topics, I will assign readings that do not come from the course textbook. These readings will be accessible on eLearning or through the library at no cost to you. Weekly readings should be engaged with before class.

Assignments & Academic Calendar

Week	Date	Topic
1	1/21	**Course Introduction – Why should we study China?** *Suggested readings:* Ang, Y. Y. (2022). How Resilient is the CCP?. *Journal of Democracy*, *33*(3), 77-91. Fukuyama, F. (1995). Confucianism and democracy. *Journal of Democracy*, *6*(2), 20-33.
2	1/26 & 1/28	**Political History: I: 1949-76** *Read before class* Joseph Ch. 2, 3 *Suggested readings:* Lieberthal, K. 2004. *Governing China: from revolution through reform*. 2nd ed. New York: W. W. Norton., Ch. 3-4. Shambaugh, D. 2021. *China's Leaders: From Mao to Now*. John Wiley & Sons, Ch. 2. Group formed, coordinator elected by 1/28
3	2/2 & 2/4	**Political History II: Reform era: 1976-2012, Xi era: 2012- present** *Read before class:* Joseph Ch. 4, 5, Saich Ch. 3 *Suggested readings:* Lieberthal, K. 2004. *Governing China: from revolution through reform*. 2nd ed. New York: W. W. Norton., Ch. 5. Shambaugh, D. 2021. *China's Leaders: From Mao to Now*. John Wiley & Sons, Ch. 6 & 7.
4	2/9 & 2/11	**Communist movement and CCP** *Read before class* Joseph Ch. 6, 7; Saich Ch. 4 *Suggested readings:* Lieberthal, K. 2004. *Governing China: from revolution through reform*. 2nd ed. New York: W. W. Norton., Ch. 6-7.
5	2/16 & 2/18	**Central and local governments** *Read before class:* Saich Ch. 5, 6 *Suggested readings:* Fewsmith, J. 2013. *The logic and limits of political reform in China*. New York: Cambridge University Press. Lü, X., & Landry, P. F. (2014). Show me the money: Interjurisdiction political competition and fiscal extraction in China. *American political science Review*, *108*(3), 706-722. Jiang, J. (2018). Making bureaucracy work: Patronage networks, performance incentives, and economic development in China. *American Journal of Political Science*, *62*(4), 982-999. Proposal due by 2/18
6	2/23 & 2/25	**Economy** *Read before class:* Joseph Ch. 9, Saich Ch. 9 *Suggested readings:* Lieberthal, K. 2004. *Governing China: from revolution through reform*. 2nd ed. New York: W. W. Norton., Ch. 8.
7	3/2 & 3/4	**Project presentation I**

8	3/9 & 3/11	**Internet Politics (3/9)** *Read before class:* Joseph Ch. 16 King, G., Pan, J., & Roberts, M. E. (2013). How censorship in China allows government criticism but silences collective expression. *American Political Science Review*, *107*(2), 326-343. *Suggested readings* DeLisle, J., Goldstein, A., & Yang, G. (Eds.). (2016). *The internet, social media, and a changing China*. University of Pennsylvania Press. **Mid-term review session (3/11)**
9	3/16 & 3/18	**Spring break**
10	3/23 & 3/25	**Mid-term exam (3/23)** **Urban-rural relations (3/25)** *Read before class:* Joseph Ch. 10, 11; Saich Ch. 8 *Suggested readings:* Lieberthal, K. 2004. *Governing China: from revolution through reform*. 2nd ed. New York: W. W. Norton., Ch. 10.
11	3/30 & 4/1	**Foreign Relations I: China-US** *Read before class:* Jisi, W., & Ran, H. (2019). From cooperative partnership to strategic competition: a review of China–US relations 2009–2019. *China International Strategy Review*, *1*(1), 1-10. Nathan, A. J., & Scobell, A. (2012). How China sees America: The sum of Beijing's fears. *Foreign Affairs*., 91(5): 32-47. Steinberg, J. B. (2019). What Went Wrong? US-China relations from Tiananmen to Trump. *Texas National Security Review*, *3*(1), 118-133. *Suggested reading:* Kang, D. C. (2007). *China rising: Peace, power, and order in East Asia*. Columbia University Press. Ch. 8. Sutter, R. G. (2021*). US-China relations: Perilous past, uncertain present*. Rowman & Littlefield.
12	4/6 & 4/8	**Foreign Relations II: China-Japan** *Read before class:* Smith, S. A. (2015). *Intimate rivals: Japanese domestic politics and a rising China*. Columbia University Press., Ch. 1 Insisa, A., & Pugliese, G. (2022). The free and open Indo-Pacific versus the belt and road: spheres of influence and Sino-Japanese relations. *The Pacific Review*, *35*(3), 557-585. *Suggested readings*: Kang, D. C. (2007). *China rising: Peace, power, and order in East Asia*. Columbia University Press. Ch. 7 Yahuda, M. (2013). *Sino-Japanese relations after the Cold War: Two tigers sharing a mountain*. Routledge.
13	4/13 & 4/15	**Greater China I: Hong Kong** *Read before class:* Joseph Ch. 19 Davis, M. C. (2022). Hong Kong: how Beijing perfected repression. *Journal of Democracy*, *33*(1), 100-115. *Suggested readings:* Lee, F. (2020). Solidarity in the anti-extradition bill movement in Hong Kong. *Critical Asian Studies*, *52*(1), 18-32.

		Lo, S. (2021). Hong Kong in 2020: National security law and truncated autonomy. *Asian Survey*, *61*(1), 34-42. Ma, N. (2025). Lost Opportunity: Local Councils and Grassroots Democracy Reforms after the Anti-Extradition Movement in Hong Kong. *Journal of Contemporary Asia*, *55*(3), 474-495.
14	4/20 & 4/22	**Greater China II: Taiwan** *Read before class:* Joseph Ch. 20 *Suggested readings:* Achen, C., & Wang, T. Y. (2017). *The Taiwan Voter*. University of Michigan Press., Ch. 1 & 7. Kang, D. C. (2007). *China rising: Peace, power, and order in East Asia*. Columbia University Press. Ch. 4.
15	4/27 & 4/29	**Final review session (4/27)** **Final exam (4/29)**
16	5/4 & 5/6	**Final presentations** **Final Report due by 5/6**

Grading Policy

1) Participation: 10%
2) Midterm Exam: 15%
3) Final Exam: 15%
4) Proposal: 10%
5) Project presentation I: 10%
6) Final presentation: 10%
7) Final project: 30%

Participation:
You will be awarded 10 percentage points for participation. Participation involves contributing to class discussions meaningfully and purposefully, asking relevant questions, and giving interesting comments. Thus, actively engaging with the class and your fellow students influences your grade. As per my attendance policy (below), you are allowed to miss up to 2 classes, no questions asked.

Midterm Exam:
The midterm exam will be administered during class. It will consist of multiple-choice, True/False, and open-ended questions. Exam worth 15 percentage points.

Final Exam:
Just like for your midterm, the final exam will be administered during class. It will consist of multiple-choice, True/False, and open-ended questions Exam worth 15 percentage points.

Final Project:
Each student must join a group of four members to work on a group project. Each group is required to present their ideas in Project Presentation I (10 minutes) and their results in the Final Presentation (10 minutes). The proposal should be no more than 5 double-spaced pages, and the final project should be around 15 double-spaced pages in length.

The proposal should include an introduction explaining why the research question is important, a tentative hypothesis describing the relationship between variables, and a discussion of data sources and references that may help the group answer the research question. Originality is the primary quality expected by the instructor.
Each group must work on a research question with clearly defined independent and dependent variables (i.e., *What does X cause Y?*) that is related to Chinese domestic politics or international relations. Students are strongly encouraged to discuss their final project topic with the instructor before the submission of the proposal.

Grading Scale:

A+ 97% - 100%	A 93% - 96%	A- 90% - 92%
B+ 87% - 89%	B 83% - 86%	B- 80% - 82%
C+ 77% - 79%	C 73% - 76%	C- 70% - 72%
D+ 67% - 69	D 63% - 66%	D- 60% - 62%

Course & Instructor Policies

Attendance, Punctuality & Participation
Consistent attendance and active participation are crucial for your success in this course and will factor into your final grade assessment. Attendance is defined as being present for the entirety of the class session.

Participation will be evaluated based on the frequency and quality of contributions to class discussions. Each student is permitted two absences from class without needing to provide an explanation or inform the instructor.

Make-Up Exams
These will only be considered for instances of an emergency (e.g., documented death of immediate relative or student hospitalization), you have an official UTD-sponsored event that conflicts with the exam date, and I am contacted via email before 8am on the day the exam (unless some documented event of force majeure prevents you to timely communicate the absence). UTD- related absences or religious holiday conflicts should be communicated to the instructor as soon as they are known, but preferably two weeks prior to exam day so we can make arrangements for the exam retake day and time. Documentation for all excused absences may be required.

Late Submissions
Assignments are expected to be submitted on the designated due date and in the specified format. Late submissions will incur a deduction of points from the assignment grade (expressed as total percentage points: 10% within 1 hour, 20% within 12 hours, 40% within 24 hours, 100% more than 24 hours).

Email Use
UT Dallas recognizes the value and efficiency of communication between faculty/staff and students through electronic mail. At the same time, email raises some issues concerning security and the identity of each individual in an email exchange. All official student email correspondence will be sent only to a student's UT Dallas email address and UT Dallas will only consider email requests originating from an official UT Dallas student email account. This allows the University to maintain a high degree of confidence in the identity of each individual corresponding via email and the security of the

transmitted information. UT Dallas furnishes each student with a free email account that is to be used in all communication with university personnel. The Office of Information Technology provides a method for students to have their UT Dallas mail forwarded to other email accounts.

Whenever you contact me by email, you can expect an answer within 2 business days of your submission. If something urgent comes up, please add the URGENT tag in the email's subject.

Academic Ethics
Every member of the UTD community is expected to maintain the highest standards of academic integrity. UTD may initiate disciplinary proceedings against a student accused of scholastic dishonesty.

Scholastic dishonesty includes, but is not limited to, statements, acts, or omissions related to applications for enrollment or the award of a degree, and/or the submission as one's own work material that is not one's own. Scholastic dishonesty may involve, but is not limited to, one or more of the following acts: cheating, plagiarism, collusion, use of annotated texts or teacher's editions, use of information about exams posted on the Internet or electronic medium, and/or
falsifying academic records. While specific examples are listed below, this is not an exhaustive list and scholastic dishonesty may encompass other conduct, including any conduct through electronic or computerized means:

- Plagiarism is the use of an author's words or ideas as if they were ones' own without giving credit to the source, including, but not limited to: failure to acknowledge a direct quotation.
- Cheating is the willful giving or receiving of information in an unauthorized manner during an examination; collaborating with another student during an examination without authority; using, buying, selling, soliciting, stealing, or otherwise obtaining course assignments and/or examination questions in advance; copying computer or Internet files; using someone else's work for assignments as if it were one's own; or any other dishonest means of attempting to fulfill the requirements of a course.
- Collusion is intentionally or unintentionally aiding or attempting to aid another in an act of scholastic dishonesty, including but not limited to, failing to secure academic work; providing a paper or project to another student; providing an inappropriate level of assistance; communicating answers to a classmate about an examination or any other course assignment; removing tests or answer sheets from a test site; and allowing a classmate to copy answers.

Class Materials
The instructor may provide class materials that will be made available to all students registered for this class as they are intended to supplement the classroom experience. These materials may be downloaded during the course; however, these materials are for registered students' use only.
Classroom materials may not be reproduced or shared with those not in class or uploaded to other online environments except to implement an approved Office of Student Accessibility accommodation. Failure to comply with these University requirements is a violation of the Student Code of Conduct.

Generative AI
The use of generative AI tools (such as ChatGPT, MS Copilot, etc.) to create content for assignments, quizzes, exams, analyses, or any other coursework is prohibited. This includes, but is not limited to, using AI to generate text, code, solutions, or any form of academic content that is submitted for evaluation.

Students are expected to complete all assignments independently and demonstrate their own understanding of the material. The use of generative AI in violation of this policy will be considered academic dishonesty and could result in disciplinary action.

Re-grading
If you think your grade should be changed due to error, submit your work and a brief written explanation of your argument to me via email. Following re-evaluation, your grade may go up or down.

Comet Creed
"As a Comet, I pledge honesty, integrity, and service in all that I do."

Technology Requirements
Each student is required to have access to a device that will allow for them to engage with course materials, whether this be a phone, laptop, or tablet. Since the text is available in digital format and quizzes will be on Blackboard, I encourage you to bring a laptop or tablet to class. I understand how difficult it is to avoid using cellphones or scrolling online while in class. Out of respect to your peers/classmates and myself, I ask that you avoid this as much as possible, as well as silence your devices when entering class. If I observe that technology use is a distraction, I will point it out.

Free Speech and Intellectual Diversity
No individual is the same and all of you come from different backgrounds and hold different positions on a wide array of topics. It is okay to have different opinions and as your instructor, I encourage you to respect and be open to different perspectives, as well as feel comfortable with sharing your own personal point of view. UTD Policy Statement on Speech Expression and Assembly: https://policy.utdallas.edu/utdsp5001.

OSA Accommodations
Americans with Disabilities Act Statement: the University of Texas at Dallas will adhere to all applicable federal, state and local laws, regulations and guidelines with respect to providing reasonable accommodations as required to afford equal educational opportunity. It is the student's responsibility to contact the OSA office, located in AD 2.224 or call at 972.883.2098 to arrange for appropriate accommodations. If you are a student with OSA Accommodations that you will be using for the rest of the course, please reach out to me via e-mail as soon as possible so that I can make sure that I am meeting your needs.

Academic Integrity
Academic dishonesty of any kind (including, but not limited to, plagiarism, sharing, copying, or cheating on exams and assignments) will not be tolerated. In accordance with UTD's Office of Community Standards and Conduct, misconduct may result in a failing grade for the course, suspension, or in some cases, expulsion. For more information, see: http://www.utdallas.edu/conduct/integrity/.

Mental Health Services and Student Support Resources
I recognize the fact that students may experience anxiety and mental health challenges brought upon by life circumstances. As UTD students, you have mental health services available to you by telephone and on campus. Student Counseling Center Phone: 972-883-2575; location: Student Services Building SSB 4.600. Moreover, UTD provides numerous resources for students in need:
The Center for Students in Recovery helps students seeking recovery from substance and alcohol use, eating disorders, and other addictions and compulsive behaviors. They also help students affected by these issues or individuals exploring the impact of addictions or compulsive behaviors within their lives. Their mission is to provide a safe, supportive community to enable students to thrive both socially and academically while living in recovery. They are located in SSB 4.500, on the fourth floor of the Student Services Building. They can be contacted by calling 972-883-7320 or they can be reached by emailing them at recovery@utdallas.edu.

The Comet Cupboard is a UT Dallas food pantry initiative dedicated to helping students in need. The Comet Cupboard is located in MC 1.604, on the first floor of the McDermott Library, and can be contacted by calling 972-883-6613 or emailing cupboard@utdallas.edu.

Comet Cents provides financial literacy to students with the peer-to-peer model. This money management center provides one-on-one appointments and workshops throughout the semester. Comet Cents works to help students improve their financial situation with topics such budgeting, credit card debit, investing and other personal finance areas.

Intercultural Programs provides a host of transition programs for international students and intercultural competency trainings for all students. They are located in SSB 3.6, on the third floor of the Student Services Building. Their phone number is 972-883-4528.

The Student Counseling Center offers confidential services to students either for individual appointments or as part of groups. Initial appointments must be made in person in the Student Counseling Center, which is located in SSB 4.600, on the fourth floor of the Student Services Building. Their main number is 972-883-2575 and the 24/7 Crisis Hotline is 972-883-8255 (972- UTD-TALK).

The Student Health Center (SHC) provides primary and preventative medical care to currently enrolled students who have paid medical fees and are attending classes. Currently enrolled students can obtain a wide variety of services, such as physicals, diagnosis and treatment of acute illnesses and injuries, general medical problems, gynecological problems, treatment of stabilized chronic illnesses, allergy injections, limited immunizations, x-rays, and ultrasound.
SHC staff of licensed medical providers is committed to keeping the UT Dallas community healthy and believes that health and wellness information complement the academic success of students.
SHC is located on the fourth floor of the Student Services Building, SSB 4.700 and they can be reached by telephone, 972-883-2747, fax, 877-769-7514, or by email, healtcen@utdallas.edu.

The Graduation Help Desk is a one-stop resource within the Office of Undergraduate Education designed to help undergraduate students overcome obstacles to a timely

graduation. The Graduation Help Desk supports undergraduate students, faculty and staff to develop solutions to complex academic and non-academic issues. This resource is equipped to promote all undergraduate students' success by helping them at any point during their academic careers from their arrival at UT Dallas until their graduation. Contact the Graduation Help Desk at graduationhelpdesk@utdallas.edu.

The Student Success Center (SSC) offers assistance to students in the areas of writing, mathematics, communication, multiple science fields, study skills, and other academic disciplines. These services are available through individual appointments, small group appointments, drop-in labs, workshops, and weekly reviews. All undergraduate students enrolled at UT Dallas are eligible to participate in these services. Not all courses will be supported by all services.
Please check the website at the beginning of each semester to find out which courses are supported by which services
In addition, students are expected to:

- know that this syllabus, including the course schedule, is subject to change at the discretion of the instructor;
- read additional related policy material at http://go.utdallas.edu/syllabus-policies.

The descriptions and timelines contained in this syllabus are subject to change at the discretion of the instructor.